

Take-Home Assignment

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The Morphology of Uncertainty: Power and Control in the Digital Age

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1 Introduction: Power, Information and Digital Society

The concept of power has always been essential for understanding societal organization, governance, and control. Throughout history, the ways in which power is exercised and maintained have undergone significant transformations. In this context, Luciano Floridi's claim that "*Whoever controls uncertainty controls society*"¹ captures the emergent form of power in the Digital Age. This period is characterised by both an unprecedented availability of information and a pervasive sense of ambiguity regarding its quality, origin, and meaning. Building on this premise, this paper investigates Floridi's concept of the morphology of uncertainty in order to identify the actors and mechanisms through which uncertainty is produced, managed, and transformed into a strategic resource of governance and influence in contemporary digital ecosystems. The objective is to highlight who controls society today and how such control over uncertainty constitutes a new and perhaps ultimate form of power.

This paper proceeds as follows. After the introduction, it first examines the historical evolution of power, leading to Floridi's conceptualisation of the morphology of uncertainty. Then, it investigates how uncertainty has become a defining feature of contemporary power, focusing on the role of major digital platforms and states in shaping and leveraging it. Finally, as the concentration of digital power raises the risk of oligopolistic structures with profound implications, the paper discusses possible scenarios and regulatory approaches, with particular attention to accountability, antitrust, and digital sovereignty.

2 From Traditional Power to the Morphology of Uncertainty

Understanding contemporary power requires tracing its historical evolution. Traditionally, whether in feudal systems or aristocracies, power was exercised through the control of material resources such as land, livestock, and even slaves. With the Industrial Revolution, control shifted to the ownership of the means of production, giving industrialists decisive influence over economic and social life. Over time, the focus of power moved from tangible assets to information about resources and processes, marking the rise of informational power. Floridi also frames a further evolution according to which, in the 21st century, the ultimate seat of power lies in the production of knowledge, which translates into the control over uncertainty. To clarify this transformation, Floridi distinguishes three fundamental forms of power. First, the poietic or creative power refers to the ability to create something new. Second, the transformative

¹Luciano Floridi, *Who controls society today?*, 2025.

or manufacturing power lies in the capacity to reshape existing entities. Third, the cybernetic or control power identifies the ability to influence or regulate behaviour, processes, and systems. In particular, while classical politics focused mainly on cybernetic power over people, the Digital Age emphasises the infrastructural control over the informational environment itself.

2.1 The Morphology of Uncertainty

Floridi argues that the most significant form of contemporary power lies in controlling the space of questions, which is composed of both the range of questions that individuals are able to formulate and the set of answers that can be accessed in response. This dynamic is captured by the concept of the morphology of uncertainty, namely the structure, shape, and distribution of the gap between questions and answers. In particular, uncertainty emerges whenever a question lacks an answer, has several conflicting answers, or when it is not even clear which questions are appropriate or meaningful. Thus, controlling the morphology of uncertainty means determining how wide this gap is, how it can be navigated, and who can move through it. Furthermore, the morphology of uncertainty identifies the architecture of knowledge production. Therefore, power no longer rests primarily in possessing information, but in organising and structuring the conditions under which information can be produced, accessed, and evaluated. This new form of power, which can manifest in different ideological systems, is infrastructural rather than explicit, as it operates through the design of the informational environment itself; for example, by filtering possibilities or guiding attention. Conceptualizing contemporary power in terms of the governance of uncertainty, Floridi provides the conceptual basis for exploring how digital platforms and states leverage this morphology to influence behaviour and shape social dynamics.

3 Uncertainty as a Tool of Digital Governance

In the Digital Age, informed by Floridi's previous insights, uncertainty is no longer merely an informational limitation but rather a powerful resource that is increasingly produced and strategically employed. In this context, governance takes an informational basis: actors shape human behaviours not by issuing explicit commands, but through new mechanisms that structure the environment itself in which choices are framed. This new form of control operates at the infrastructural level, making it more pervasive, less visible, and significantly harder to challenge than traditional institutional power. Furthermore, this strategic uncertainty is embedded within both private and public forms of digital governance. On the one hand, major digital platforms govern the informational environment through algorithmic infrastructures that mediate visibility, attention, and access to information. On the other hand, states deploy complementary practices of surveillance, regulation, and informational control.

3.1 Platform-Driven Governance

Major digital platforms exercise a new form of governance based on their central position within the Infosphere. This power relies on leveraging the inherent informational uncertainty and converting it into a highly controlled variable in order to shape various societal dynamics.

Amazon exemplifies the capitalist pursuit towards the concentration of power and control in the Digital Age². Similarly to other large digital platforms such as Google and Facebook, it extracts and exploits data to accumulate economic power and control, influencing purchasing decisions through highlighting

²Andrea Coveri et al., *Monopoly Capital in the time of digital platforms: a radical approach to the Amazon case*, 2022.

and recommendations. Yet Amazon’s power extends beyond data gateways. Indeed, by expanding the number of goods sold on its marketplace, Amazon has become the first option for customers, wholesalers, and third-party sellers all over the world. As a consequence, it can use “predatory” pricing strategies based on discounts and market subsidization, with which new markets and sectors struggle to keep up. Moreover, with its reach, Amazon increases the amount of data used to improve market strategies, feeding it to AI algorithms that govern the platform. This combination of pricing power, data-driven insights, and global reach allows Amazon to strengthen its dominance by shaping customer behaviour and reinforcing dependence on its services. Therefore, algorithmic recommendations resolve informational uncertainty for users, but in a way that is strategically biased toward Amazon’s interests.

However, the key point that makes Amazon unlike other corporations is that it expands its reach into other markets while investing in assets and technologies that allow it to maintain control over its digital networks, such as big data extraction, storage, and analytics. Expanding, for example, into AI technologies, particularly natural language recognition, Amazon designed Alexa, a digital personal assistant that enables individuals to purchase goods or access Amazon services with voice commands. This creates users’ dependence on the company’s services, as well as additional data harnessing and control. These strategies have made Amazon the most valuable US-based digital company, with its share value rising in recent years, allowing it to enforce and expand its control over the economic system.

On the contrary, if Amazon governs by resolving uncertainty, TikTok governs by producing and modulating it. The platform functions almost entirely on algorithmic curation, with the vast majority of the videos seen by users selected by the recommendation system rather than direct engagement, such as follows or subscriptions³. The system rapidly personalizes content based on time spent watching videos on a specific topic, increasingly emphasizing similar material and resulting in a loop. This demonstrates how TikTok’s algorithm is not merely reflective of user interests but actively shapes them. Therefore, TikTok’s power lies not only in predicting what users want to see but also in shaping what becomes perceptible in the first place. According to Louise Amoore in the book “Cloud Ethics”, algorithms transform how people perceive and interact with the world. The author argues that they are embedded with assumptions, biases, and probability weightings, which not only influence their outputs but also shape their ethical and political existence. In this sense, algorithms govern by filtering reality into what is deemed relevant, transforming uncertainty into a controlled variable. Each interaction contributes to that reinforcement loop, which reduces uncertainty for the user while amplifying it about the broader informational environment.

In all cases, platform-driven governance over uncertainty is exercised by structuring the overall environment in which decisions are made, effectively shaping user behaviour. Capturing and directing attention becomes an extremely powerful form of control, shifting the focus from individual autonomous agency to the design and operation of the digital system itself.

3.2 State-Driven Governance

State-driven governance is a system in which the government holds primary power over political, social, and informational structures. In these systems, the state actively shapes public behaviour and controls important resources, including information, to maintain stability, legitimacy, and control. This model often features centralized decision-making, limited transparency, and strong influence over communica-

³Julia Salles, *Affect and prediction in short-video social media recommendation algorithm: TikTok and the missing half second*, 2025.

tion channels, especially in more authoritarian settings. When looking at how states use information and uncertainty as tools of governance, Nepal and North Korea offer two different examples.

In Nepal, governance operates within a democratic framework. However, public frustration has increased due to corruption, political inefficiency, and a lack of accountability. This situation allowed for Gen-Z-led digital protests to emerge, facilitated by the easy circulation of information on platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Facebook. Young people used digital spaces to voice their concerns, coordinate protests, and challenge authorities. Yet, this rapid dissemination of content also creates uncertainty. Unverified claims, competing narratives, and emotional content spread quickly due to algorithmic amplification. In this context, power became shared, not entirely controlled by the state but influenced by digital platforms and online communities. The situation in Nepal shows a governance environment where uncertainty acts as an incentive for mobilization, shifting informational power toward citizens. In contrast, North Korea represents one of the most extreme examples of state-driven governance. The government maintains strict control over political, economic, and social life, including near-total control of information. Internet access is heavily restricted, and internal networks are monitored by the state. Media acts as a tool for shaping narratives and limiting exposure to different viewpoints. By controlling information, the state reduces uncertainty, ensuring that citizens receive only curated and approved messages. In this system, uncertainty cannot grow; it is tightly managed to maintain compliance. The state holds exclusive power over information, preventing digital mobilization or dissent.

Together, they illustrate how different governance models handle control over uncertainty. Nepal represents a system in which digital platforms generate uncertainty while enabling citizen mobilization, turning information into a contested space among the state, platforms, and the public. Instead, North Korea exemplifies the opposite extreme: a strict form of state-driven governance where information is monopolized to maintain stability, and uncertainty is minimized to prevent disruption.

4 Digital Power Concentration: Implications, Scenarios and Regulatory Responses

When power is gained through uncertainty, one of the most visible consequences in the public sphere is mistrust towards large corporations. A 2022 study⁴, conducted at New York University in Abu Dhabi, revealed that the vast majority of respondents expressed deep concern about Big Tech misusing their personal data. Even though the widespread belief that companies “listen” through mobile phones’ microphones lacks empirical support, people perception of the approach used by these companies towards their privacy is negative, with many believing that their privacy is at such risk that they consider switching off their phones while discussing something important. The study’s physical experiment, however, which consisted of exposing iOS and Android devices to audio advertisements, showed an opposite result to the gathered opinion: at least in the case of Facebook mobile application, no evidence was found of users being recorded. A more plausible explanation for the perceived “eavesdropping” data is the use of major browsers that employ third-party cookies, which track the user’s activity across different websites by placing a small piece of data on the device. This process allows advertisers to build a profile based on the user’s interests, demographics, habits, and location across the sites the user visits, enabling advertisers to provide personalized and targeted messages.

⁴Mikołaj Artur Dębicki, *Oligopoly of Big-Tech companies despite global mistrust*, 2022.

Despite privacy concerns and regulatory pressure, companies such as Google cannot simply phase out third-party cookies from their browsers. Instead, they are focusing more on a “user-customizable choices” model, allowing users to manage their cookie preferences in Chrome’s privacy settings. Yet this approach raises a normative question: should the default be user consent to activate tracking, rather than requiring users to turn it off? Nonetheless, Google is continuing to develop privacy-preserving technologies such as Topics API, which is designed to preserve privacy while showing relevant ads based on recent browsing history without using third-party cookies. Still, it is reasonable to argue that these changes remain insufficient, as control continues to reside with the platform and not the user. Moreover, Floridi warns of an impending risk of oligopoly, where fewer individuals, companies, and centres control this morphology of uncertainty and the power it generates. To directly address this challenge democratically, Floridi suggests two complementary mechanisms: accountability and antitrust.

4.1 Accountability

In a democratic society, control is ultimately in the hands of the majority. Yet the fact that the governed have power over the governors is often taken for granted. Those in positions of control should be held accountable to the citizens who entrusted them with power, and should have the responsibility to implement changes when society is dissatisfied. Within the context of uncertainty in the Digital Age, accountability becomes even more crucial. Rather than diminishing responsibility, uncertainty should reinforce transparency, particularly in how data is collected, processed, and used.

4.2 Antitrust

Accountability alone, however, is limited to the political sphere, since corporations are not elected. This is why regulations that prevent the concentration of economic power regarding monopolies and sustain competition are needed. This mechanism is known as antitrust. In today’s digital society, where power lies in controlling uncertainty, major companies are no longer contesting market share but are instead dividing spheres of influence. For this reason, in an environment where political accountability alone is insufficient and economic competition has eroded, antitrust policies become necessary.

5 Conclusion: Who Controls Uncertainty, and thus Society?

In conclusion, the question of who controls society is specifically a question of who governs the infrastructures through which information is produced, circulated, and interpreted. The central challenge in today’s society is to re-establish politics as a mechanism of responsibility in the digital sphere, as digital technologies are now perceived as operating outside ordinary politics. This challenge is called digital sovereignty. For example, in Europe, this sovereignty is being constructed through the GDPR, AI Act, and other regulatory frameworks designed to restore political authority as a mechanism of control. In the United States, by contrast, the challenge is to revive antitrust traditions, that have ceased since the Clinton era, to ensure strong and genuine competition among major corporations in order to allow the subjects of their control to retain the final say.

Therefore, democratic control over uncertainty requires that platforms themselves be subject to control and be aware that control today no longer concerns information alone, but also the infrastructures that enable its production and circulation. Only by acting at this level can democracy make a meaningful difference, enabling society to reclaim the power to shape uncertainty.